Remote Controller with Fail-Safe Update

Concept of Operations

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1.0 Introduction

1.1 Project Description

1.1.1 Background

Purpose: The System lets an operator on the ground command, monitor, and update a controller in space that nobody can reach, and keeps that controller working between contacts.

Need: A controller that nobody can reach must stay operable, observable, and correctable for its whole life. Operation, observability, and maintenance including in-flight modification over the specified lifetime are three areas a space software specification must cover [3, Annex B, items 5.11–5.13, p. 113].

Worst-Case Failure: A failed update can leave the controller unable to run any firmware and unable to accept new firmware. Without physical access, that state is permanent.

Rationale: The loss has happened. NASA records a mission terminated after an in-flight software upload omitted a patch for a defective countdown timer; its recommendations include test-bed verification of in-flight software updates [4, Lesson 0559, p. 199].

1.1.2 Assumptions and Constraints

C-1 The ground cannot talk to the controller directly. Every command, report, and firmware image passes through the onboard computer.

C-2 All software is built to NASA's software engineering requirements. Rigor per part is set by its software class [5, Sec. 3.5.1, p. 24; App. C].

C-3 One engineer builds and checks the System. No independent team reviews the work.

C-4 The System runs on commercial development boards, not on spacecraft hardware. It can show how the System behaves, not that it would survive launch or space.

A-1 Once launched, physical access to the onboard computer or controller is impossible; all fixes and updates must arrive by radio.

A-2 The controller can lose power at any moment, even halfway through writing new firmware. The System must survive that without losing the controller [2, App. A, Table 2, p. 63].

A-3 The ground can reach the spacecraft only during line-of-sight contact windows **[TBD-5]**. Between contacts the System must work on its own.

A-4 One person operates the ground station. No second person checks a command before it is sent, so the System itself must refuse wrong commands.

A-5 Radiation in space can flip single bits in memory, so stored firmware can change on its own. The System must not run firmware that has changed [2, App. A, Table 2, p. 63].

Note. *A constraint (C) is a limit the System must work within; it is imposed, not chosen. An assumption (A) is a condition taken as true without proof; the design depends on it, and if it proves false the design may be wrong.* ***[TBR-****n****]*** *marks a proposal the author has not yet accepted;* ***[TBD-****n****]*** *marks a value not yet known. Both are listed in App. C.*

1.2 Overview of the Envisioned System

1.2.1 Overview

The System comprises two spatially separated operational segments. The **ground segment** on Earth includes the operator, the mission operations center running ground software, and the ground station antenna [6, Sec. 11.2, p. 305]. The **space segment** in orbit consists of the onboard computer and the controller, which operate without physical access.

Communication between segments is strictly established via a radio link during line-of-sight contact windows [**TBD-5**]. Outside contact windows, the space segment operates autonomously. Within the spacecraft, the onboard computer communicates with the controller over the data link during normal operation. If the controller's main firmware fails to execute, the onboard computer utilizes the reprogramming link to restore functional firmware independently of the controller's primary software. Figure 1 illustrates this segment layout.

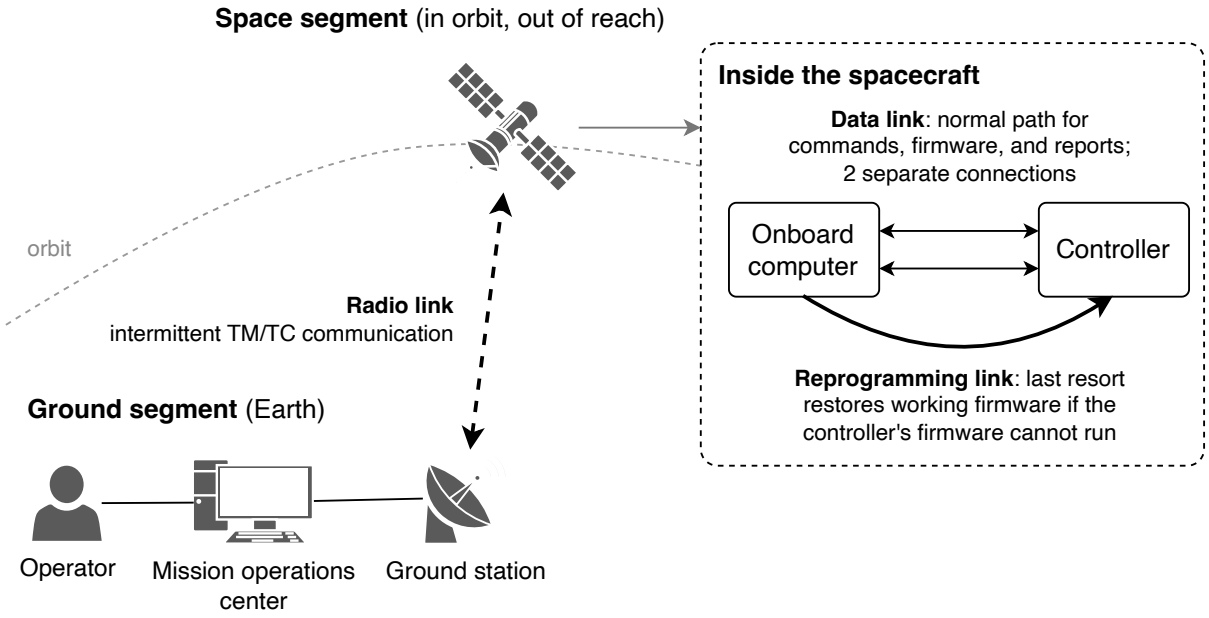


Figure 1: Ground and space segments, joined only by the radio link during contact windows. Inside the spacecraft, the data link handles normal communication, while the reprogramming link restores working firmware if the controller's firmware cannot run.

1.2.2 System Scope

Size and complexity

- Software: three programs to build and verify: the ground software in the mission operations center, the onboard computer's software, and the controller's firmware.
- Modes: the controller moves between four modes: running confirmed firmware, trying new firmware, falling back to older firmware, and being restored by the onboard computer.
- Situations: the System must handle 27 situations, and 24 of them are failures, for example power lost during an update, new firmware that hangs, or a lost connection.
- Program size: not known until the architecture is chosen [**TBD-10**].

External interfaces

- The radio equipment at both ends of the radio link.
- The spacecraft power supply feeding the onboard computer and the controller. Its loss is assumption A-2.

Enabling systems (needed to build and test the System, not part of it)

- The tools that build and release firmware.
- The bench setup that degrades the radio link and injects faults (VER-1, VER-2).

In scope

- **Commanding:** commands from the ground, through the onboard computer, to the controller.
- **Telemetry:** reports from the controller and the onboard computer back to the ground.

- **Fault handling between contacts:** detecting faults and responding without the ground [**TBR-5**].
- **Firmware updates:** updating and restoring the controller's firmware in flight.

Out of scope

- **Onboard computer software updates:** updating or restoring the onboard computer's own software [**TBR-7**].
- **Radio equipment:** RF front ends, antennas and ground transceivers, used as given and not developed here.

2.0 Documents

2.1 Applicable Documents

[1] NASA, *NASA Systems Engineering Handbook*, NASA/SP-2016-6105 Rev 2, 2016. This outline follows its App. S, pp. 251–253, tailored per its Sec. 3.11.1, p. 34: Section 7.0 not applicable; App. C added for open items per its App. C, pp. 197–198.

2.2 Reference Documents

[2] NASA, *Software Assurance and Software Safety Standard*, NASA-STD-8739.8B, 2022. Off-nominal scenarios cite App. A, Table 2.
[3] ESA, *Space engineering — Software*, ECSS-E-ST-40C Rev. 1, 30 April 2025.
[4] NASA, *Fault Management Handbook*, NASA-HDBK-1002, Draft 2, 2 April 2012. A draft, not a released standard.
[5] NASA, *NASA Software Engineering Requirements*, NPR 7150.2D.
[6] NASA, *State-of-the-Art of Small Spacecraft Technology*, Chapter 11, "Ground Data Systems and Mission Operations", 2026 edition. Ground system architecture in Sec. 11.2 and Fig. 11.2, pp. 305–306.

3.0 Description of Envisioned System

3.1 Needs, Goals and Objectives

NEED A controller that nobody can reach must stay operable, observable and correctable for its whole life. The three properties are three areas a space software specification must cover: operation, observability, and maintenance including in-flight modification over the specified lifetime [3, Annex B, items 5.11–5.13, p. 113].

G-5 Operable: the controller keeps running its function and acts on the operator's commands. Capabilities CMD, FM.

G-6 Observable: the ground can know what the System is doing, how healthy it is, and what happened between contacts. Capabilities TM.

G-7 Correctable: the controller's firmware can be replaced for its whole life without losing the controller. Capabilities UPD.

G-1 No update, and no failure during one, leaves the controller without firmware it can run.

G-2 The System acts only on firmware and commands from the operator.

G-3 Losing one connection of the data link stops nothing.

G-4 Between contacts the System handles faults alone and reports them later [**TBR-5**].

O-1 Every scenario in Section 6.0 is demonstrated on hardware and recorded.

N-1 Retired during drafting; now G-7. NASA requires a single need statement [1, Sec. 4.1, p. 49].

N-2 Retired during drafting; now G-6.

N-3 Retired during drafting; now G-5.

3.2 Overview of System and Key Elements

Operator Releases firmware, decides commands, reads reports. Works through the mission operations center.

Mission operations center Runs the ground software: commands the spacecraft and monitors its performance [6, Sec. 11.2, p. 305]. Packages released firmware, checks commands before they are sent, and stores reports.

Ground station The antenna and radio that carry the radio link during contacts [6, Sec. 11.2, p. 305].

Onboard computer Checks and passes on firmware and commands, stores reports, watches and restores the controller.

Controller Runs its function, reports, keeps known-good firmware to fall back on.

3.3 Interfaces

Radio link The only connection between the ground and the spacecraft. Commands and firmware go up; reports come down. It exists only during contact windows.

Data link The normal path between the onboard computer and the controller. Commands and new firmware go to the controller; reports come back. It works only while the controller's firmware runs. It has two separate connections: if one fails, the other carries everything.

Reprogramming link The last-resort path, used only when the controller's firmware cannot run. It restores working firmware without any help from the controller's own software.

3.4 Modes of Operations

OPERATE Runs confirmed firmware. New firmware can arrive [**TBR-6**].

TRIAL Runs new firmware not yet judged good [**TBD-6**].

FALLBACK Runs previous or last-resort firmware after a failed trial or start.

RECOVERY Runs no firmware. The onboard computer restores it through the reprogramming link.

3.5 Proposed Capabilities

TM-1 Send regular health reports: alive, firmware, uptime, last restart reason, temperature [**TBR-4**].

TM-2 Report important events at once [**TBR-4**].

TM-3 Timestamp every report [**TBR-4**].

TM-4 Store reports between contacts, send all at the next one, report any lost.

TM-5 Report the health of each data-link connection [**TBR-4**].

CMD-1 Accept commands only from the operator. Refuse replayed commands.

CMD-2 Answer every command: received, refused with reason, or done with result.

CMD-3 Refuse commands not allowed in the current state.

CMD-4 Run a resent command at most once.

CMD-5 Dangerous commands need two steps: arm, then execute.

CMD-6 Refuse impossible values.

CMD-7 Let the operator cancel an update, leaving known-good firmware running.

CMD-8 Run commands at a set time. Refuse expired commands.

CMD-9 Log every command and its answer.
FM-1 Notice a silent controller and try to bring it back [**TBR-5**].
FM-2 Carry on over the other connection when one dies [**TBR-5**].
FM-3 Restart crashed onboard programs and continue [**TBR-5**].
FM-4 Record every fault and action for the ground [**TBR-5**].
UPD-1 Take firmware from the ground through dropping links.
UPD-2 Refuse firmware that is damaged, not from the operator, for something else, or below the minimum version.
UPD-3 Get the firmware to the controller.
UPD-4 Switch the controller to it [**TBD-3**].
UPD-5 Decide whether it is good [**TBD-4**].
UPD-6 Go back to working firmware if not, with nobody's help.
UPD-7 Tell the ground what happened.
UPD-8 Never leave the controller without runnable firmware.
VER-1 Degrade the radio link on purpose (test only).
VER-2 Cut controller power and break one connection on command (test only) [**TBR-10**].

4.0 Physical Environment

Follows from the situation in which nobody can reach the System. Response legend [1, App. S, p. 252]: OPERATE = all functions continue; SURVIVE = functions stop and return when the condition ends.

Condition	Response	Scenario
No ground contact	OPERATE	OPS-110
Controller power loss at any instant	SURVIVE	OPS-340
Single-bit memory error	OPERATE	OPS-400
Temperature range	[**TBD-9**]	—

5.0 Support Environment

Firmware is built and released on the ground and sent up during contacts, one transfer across several if needed. The onboard computer keeps the last known-good firmware. Update rate [**TBD-8**]. Nothing is repaired after deployment.

6.0 Operational Scenarios

6.1 Nominal Conditions

OPS-100 Update: release, upload over one or more contacts, check, transfer [**TBR-6**], switch [**TBD-3**], judged good [**TBD-4**], confirmed, outcome reported.
OPS-110 Telemetry: reports stamped and stored between contacts, all sent at the next one.
OPS-120 Scheduled command: received during a contact, runs at its time, answer sent at the next contact.

6.2 Off-Nominal Conditions

Trigger, then expected outcome. Sources in brackets are items of [2, App. A, Table 2].
OPS-200 Ground link lost mid-transfer: resumes next contact where it stopped.
OPS-210 Command not from operator or replayed: refused, logged [2, p. 62].
OPS-220 Answer lost, command resent: not run again, "already done".
OPS-230 Command wrong for current state: refused with reason [2, p. 63].

OPS-240 Impossible value: refused with reason [2, p. 62].
OPS-250 Dangerous command not armed: refused with reason.
OPS-260 Command expired: refused with reason [2, p. 63].
OPS-270 Report storage full: ground told how many were lost.
OPS-300 Firmware damaged in transfer: refused before the controller [2, p. 63].
OPS-310 Firmware not from operator: refused.
OPS-320 Firmware below minimum version: refused.
OPS-330 Firmware for another controller: refused [2, p. 63].
OPS-340 Power lost during firmware write: previous firmware runs; retry possible [2, p. 63].
OPS-350 New firmware hangs: back to previous, unaided.
OPS-360 New firmware restart loop: back to previous after **[TBD-7]** starts [2, p. 64].
OPS-370 New firmware never judged good: back to previous.
OPS-380 Previous firmware also bad: last-resort firmware runs.
OPS-390 Operator cancels update: known-good firmware left running.
OPS-400 Bit error in stored firmware: detected, not run **[TBR-9]** [2, p. 63].
OPS-410 No firmware can run: restored through the reprogramming link [2, p. 63].
OPS-500 One data-link connection fails: everything continues on the other; reported.
OPS-510 Both data-link connections fail: controller keeps working; loss reported; reprogramming link still usable **[TBR-8]**.
OPS-520 Controller silent: noticed, recovery tried, recorded **[TBR-5]**.
OPS-530 Onboard program crash: it restarts and resumes any update; the controller is unaffected **[TBR-5]**.

7.0 Impact Considerations

Not applicable: bench demonstration.

8.0 Risks and Potential Issues

R-1 Both data-link connections may share software; one defect could cut both.
R-2 Controller memory may not hold last-resort plus two working firmwares.
R-3 Second data-link connection and reprogramming link not yet shown on bench.
R-4 Demonstration date **[TBD-2]**; undemonstrated scenarios are declared, not dropped.

A Acronyms

CMD command; ConOps Concept of Operations; FM fault management; MOC mission operations center; OPS operational scenario; TC telecommand; TBD To Be Determined; TBR To Be Resolved; TM telemetry; UPD update; VER verification.

B Glossary

Confirmed Firmware judged good after its trial; only confirmed firmware is known-good.
Last-resort Known-good firmware that updates never replace (golden image).
Switch The controller stops running old firmware and starts the new.
Arm First step of a dangerous command; changes nothing alone.
Expiry Time after which a waiting command is refused.

C Open Items

Unmarked statements were stated or accepted by the author on 9–10 October 2026. TBR items are resolved before the hazard analysis.

Resolved

TBR-1 Spacecraft controller, ground contacts only, no physical access, bench stand-in, bit errors occur, no repair. Accepted by the author, 10 October 2026.
TBR-2 Controller power can drop at any instant, including mid-write. Accepted by the author, 10 October 2026.
TBR-3 One operator. Accepted by the author, 10 October 2026.

Open

TBR-4 TM-1, TM-2, TM-3, TM-5 as written (shown 10 Oct, not yet accepted).
TBR-5 G-4, FM-1 to FM-4 as written (shown 10 Oct, not yet accepted).
TBR-6 Controller keeps working while new firmware arrives.
TBR-7 Onboard computer's own update out of scope.
TBR-8 Reprogramming link still usable with both data-link connections lost.
TBR-9 Stored firmware checked before start; damaged copy skipped.
TBR-10 Test setup can cut power and break one connection.
TBD-1 Project name and document reference.
TBD-2 Demonstration date.
TBD-3 Switch automatically on arrival, or only on operator command.
TBD-4 Who judges new firmware good: controller or operator.
TBD-5 Contact window length and gap (sourced, or a test parameter).
TBD-6 Trial time limit (requirements).
TBD-7 Failed starts before going back (requirements).
TBD-8 Update rate.
TBD-9 Temperature range.
TBD-10 Code size of each program. Estimated after the architecture.